World and Settlements of Aetheln

Document Status

This is the canonical world and settlement summary for the faction-based, mandatory open-world-PvP direction. Settlement names remain subject to creative and legal review.

Playable origins, anatomy, and cultural-heritage rules are defined in Playable Peoples.

Cosmology

Before the world there was the Deepwake, an ocean of unrealized lives and histories - everything that could have happened and did not. The Waking Star emerged from it: a partly sentient memory engine that dreamed Aetheln into physical existence by realizing some histories and rejecting the rest. Whether the Star intends anything by what it realizes remains disputed, and that dispute is deliberate canon.

The Star's light is life, magic, and memory. Three wounded Wardens tend its remaining influence. The Wardens are metaphysical functions of how the Star remembers, not conventional gods; they are prayed to, but they are aspects of the engine, not persons who answer:

- **Sother:** kindling, dawn, law, and order.
- **Vael:** the deep, dusk, dreams, and mystery.
- **Ninh:** change, death, renewal, and turning.

The Wardens do not map cleanly to the two player factions.

Spirits and the Light

Spirits are coherent local continuities of realized lives and places within Aetheln. Their knowledge is bounded by the histories they carry. They may remember incompletely, disagree, or misunderstand a change beyond their own experience; they cannot judge every person or reveal a certain future. They are distinct from the Wardens, falling Embers, and Forgettings. Their existence does not establish that every dead person's soul remains available to consult.

The Star dreamed the Vesh separately from Aurin and Kell before the Duskbreak as mortal embodied spirit creatures connected to these presences. They are a people with lives of their own, not deceased members of another people, spent Embers reincarnated, or servants manufactured by the Wardens. Their existence does not establish which people the Star dreamed first.

Vesh speak of following the Light: an ethical and spiritual call to attention, compassion, and discernment. Enlightenment is a fallible discipline rather than proof of moral purity. Individuals may interpret, neglect, or misuse what they hear. A guiding encounter does not prove the Star's intention or absolve its listener of responsibility. No faction has an exclusive claim to the Light.

Spirit listening is learned practice open to every people. It does not grant racial combat power, certain prophecy, or automatic detection of hidden people. Spirit accounts must be investigated alongside living witnesses and records; they cannot replace the coherent witnessed record required for Emberbound restoration.

The Duskbreak

The Lucent Choir attempted the Great Concordance: binding the Waking Star's light permanently into the world, ending death, and forcing incompatible histories to coexist. The Concordance cracked the Star, glassed civilizations, and began the world's slow dimming.

Fragments of the wounded Star now fall as Embers - rejected memories seeking realization. Settlements need Embers to survive, while the Ashen Choir gathers them to complete the original ritual. Where the Duskbreak tore continuity away entirely, Forgettings remain: people, creatures, and places that still exist but have lost the history that made them coherent.

Present Conflict

The Concord traditionally regulates all contested Ember use. The world has now divided between two coalitions:

- The **Crowned Ledger** believes shared law and central control are necessary for survival. It preserves accountable continuity but risks owned truth.
- The **Hundred Witnesses** believe local communities and finders must control the light they preserve or recover. They protect plurality but risk fragmentation and paralysis.

These are working faction names; under Issue #104 they supersede the earlier working names Dawn Concordat and Unbound Flame, and final faction naming is owned by Issue #54. Both factions fight the Ashen Choir while also fighting each other over territory, Emberfalls, routes, ruins, and political control.

Territory Model

Every world region must declare:

- Territory owner or neutral status.
- PvP state.

- Recommended progression band.
- Respawn and reinforcement rules.
- Resource risk and banking locations.
- Faction objectives.
- Settlement services.
- Duskbreak scar.

Regions may contain more-specific subzones. The server resolves policy from the region through the most-specific matching subzone; an explicit sanctuary, respawn, beginner, or other protection rule takes precedence over a containing mixed territory's hostility.

Protected Starting Territories

Each faction has a distinct homeland experience. Rival players do not enter its beginner districts during normal play.

These territories provide:

- Faction-specific opening quests.
- Class and combat training.
- Early equipment and permanent levels.
- Introduction to the faction Doctrine.
- A clear narrative reason to cross into mixed territory.

Mixed Territories

Mixed territories host quests for both factions and enable mandatory faction PvP except inside explicit server-authoritative sanctuary subzones. There is no voluntary flag.

They combine:

- Shared PvE enemies.
- Faction-specific quest interpretations.
- Contested Emberfalls.
- Resource transport and banking.
- World bosses.
- Forts, routes, watchtowers, and field objectives.
- Safe mixed cities with sanctuary boundaries.

Faction Capitals

Faction capitals support trade, training, governance, faction services, and invasion gameplay.

Individuals may infiltrate through difficult routes. Organized groups may attack gates and military objectives. Beginner districts remain inaccessible, and invasion outcomes cannot permanently remove essential services.

Capital military and invasion subzones are separate security and topology domains from protected beginner districts. An invasion route never grants travel or simulation authority over beginner content.

Major Settlements

Kindlehold - The Last Lit City

Kindlehold surrounds the Kindlespire, the largest surviving shard of the Star's light.

Revised role:

- Neutral seat of the Concord.
- Primary safe mixed city.
- Shared trade, crafting, diplomacy, and story services.
- Meeting point for cross-faction threats such as the Ashen Choir.
- Sanctuary where the server rejects hostile activation and effect application.

Kindlehold is not either faction's main capital. Its neutrality is unstable and politically valuable.

Branmark - The Tithe City

Branmark is an Aurin fortress city built over a failing light-well. Every lamp is measured and every household contributes to the light-tithe.

Revised role:

- Major Crowned Ledger stronghold and candidate faction capital.
- Defensive Doctrine training and regulated Ember logistics.
- Invasion objectives centered on tithe gates, barracks, signal towers, and a protected Ember registry.
- Outer rings remain visibly glassed from the Duskbreak.

The final choice of faction capital remains open because all peoples may join either faction.

Graefell - The Undervault

Graefell is carved into the canyon where the first Kell awakened before the Duskbreak. The Star's dreaming realized living quartz and amethyst there; Graefell remembers that first awakening without claiming that Kell preceded the other peoples. The catastrophe later fused the surrounding canyon

into inert glass. The contrast defines the Undervault: living layered bodies still grow and change among surfaces fixed by disaster.

Its architecture follows curved mineral strata, with crafted supports joining older surfaces to newer work. Maintained seams remain visible as records of care. Geode archives preserve dying light as memory through learned craft; they are constructed vessels and institutions, not harvested Kell bodies. Keepers from every people can study and maintain them.

Graefell's cultural dispute is whether keeping a memory creates a claim over its subject. Some archives treat custody as a duty that ends when the witness asks for release. Others consider any surrendered record part of a heritage too valuable for one person to withdraw. The Duskbreak's losses make both positions urgent, and Vothram's secret preservation and Corvath's living glass make the argument impossible to keep abstract.

Revised role:

- Politically aligned with Hundred Witnesses arguments about local ownership.
- Crafting and memory-archive center.
- Possible Hundred Witnesses stronghold, but not automatically race-locked.
- Source of archive dungeons and disputes over whether memory can be privately held, who must care for it, and who may consent to its release.

Selaen - The Drift

Selaen is an airborne convoy of Vesh lantern-craft platforms that follows observed Ember currents and estimates the paths of Emberfalls. Resonant lantern engines ride those currents to suspend and steer the convoy. Navigators compare measured conditions, route records, and fallible local spirit guidance; an encounter cannot guarantee a safe passage. Neither captured spirits nor captured Starlight fuel routine travel. Vesh bodies cannot fly.

Its lantern caravans connect scattered communities, carrying supplies, living witnesses, and records. Spirit interpreters travel alongside other craftspeople and route observers. The convoy's recurring dilemma is whether to divert toward an endangered place and its spirits when doing so would break a supply promise to another community. Following the Light still requires choosing whom its limited care can reach.

Revised role:

- Mobile neutral or conditionally aligned settlement.
- Seasonal arrival point in mixed territory.
- Source of current observations, spirit testimony, rare trade, and changing world objectives.
- Safe sanctuary only while stationed inside a defined mixed-city boundary.

Its final political status remains open.

Glasswake Reach

The Glasswake Reach is a plain of grassland and ruins fused into rippling glass by the Duskbreak. Living pockets grow where new Embers seed the land.

It contains:

- The Weeping Spire.
- The Mirrorfields.
- Emberwatch.
- Lanternrest.
- The Duskvigil.
- The Hollow Choirhouse.

The existing PvE story follows refugees, unstable Ember-wells, the Ashen Choir, and Choirmaster Sevrin Vale.

For production, the first Glasswake slice may remain a controlled cooperative test region. Its final-world version must declare whether it is faction-owned or mixed. That decision is still open and must be resolved before final quest and server topology work.

Emberwatch

A refugee waystation built around a cracked Ember-well.

Functions:

- Early quest services.
- Warden-priest presence.
- Repair, supplies, and travel.
- Block and defensive-combat teaching.

Lanternrest

A Vesh caravan circle marked by a constructed, semi-living Mother-Lantern: a cultural vessel where local spirits may voluntarily meet listeners. It is neither a spirit prison nor an oracle. Its keepers compare testimony with refugees' accounts and carried records; spirits are free to leave and may decline to speak. The lantern caravans gather here to exchange supplies, witnesses, and news before continuing their routes.

Functions:

- Spirit listening, investigation, and Ashen Choir foreshadowing.
- Caravan and escort quests.
- Cosmetic and travel services.

- Dodge, pursuit, and threat-reading teaching.

The Quieting - Working Name

At Lanternrest, spirits from unrelated places begin repeating identical testimony. The agreement first appears comforting, but their accounts lose the particular names, disagreements, and attachments that made each a local witness. Listeners investigate through refugees, route observations, and kept records rather than accepting unanimity as proof of the Light's guidance.

The Ashen Choir is harmonizing these voices into the Onefold Vault, forcing distinct continuities toward one account. The danger is not that a spirit disagrees with a listener, but that it can no longer express its own history or choose whether to bear witness. Sevrin presents the quiet as relief from contradiction and suffering, bringing the crisis beside the Unison's promise of enforced mercy.

Selaen must weigh a threatened place and its remaining spirits against supply obligations to another settlement. Crowned Ledger investigators seek accountable custody and comparable records, risking the confinement of witnesses in the name of protection. Hundred Witnesses delegates defend local consent and the right to leave, risking fragmented evidence and delayed action. Neither method alone establishes what compassion requires.

The story asks whether rescue restores a witness's ability to speak or remain silent, whether release can be honored despite losing testimony, and when preservation becomes another form of coercion. Nhalen presses for care without a verdict on faith; Saeril must distinguish her ninth light's warning from evidence before using her public authority. The Quieting is a narrative arc, not approval of additional release scope, quest quantities, or numeric rules.

The Duskvigil

A Ninh-priest cloister overlooking the Hollow Choirhouse.

Functions:

- Dungeon staging.
- Ashen Choir investigation.
- Repair and travel.
- Interruption and encounter-preparation teaching.

The Hollow Choir

The Hollow Choir is the initial cooperative dungeon. Sevrin Vale and the Ashen Choir are attempting to complete the ritual that cracked the Star.

The dungeon teaches and tests:

- Telegraph recognition.
- Directional block.
- Dodge timing.
- Interruption.
- Guard pressure.
- Space control.
- Ally protection.

Its rewards feed permanent PvE progression and prepare characters for mixed territory without making dungeon equipment an automatic PvP victory.

Future Regions

Faction Homeland A

The Crowned Ledger requires a complete starting region with its own settlement, quest sequence, Doctrine introduction, and border transition. Branmark is a candidate anchor.

Faction Homeland B

The Hundred Witnesses require an equivalent but not identical starting region. Graefell is a candidate anchor.

Equivalent means comparable progression time, opportunity, and production quality. It does not require mirrored geography or quests.

The First City

The ruined golden-age capital was glassed almost whole. It is a future high-level PvE, PvP, dungeon, or raid location.

Grael Forest Holds

Future settlements built around beast-touched symbiosis.

Emberborn Communes

Future communities of people reincarnated from spent Embers.

World Flow

1. Faction-specific protected homeland.

2. Faction border and frontier warning.
3. Mandatory-PvP mixed territory outside explicit sanctuary subzones.
4. Safe mixed-city sanctuary for banking and services.
5. More dangerous mixed regions and world encounters.
6. Enemy infiltration and faction-capital invasions.
7. Seasonal movement of Selaen and major Emberfalls.

Contested-Territory Objectives

Mixed territories should concentrate players around objectives with world and faction value rather than make random killing the fastest progression path.

Objective types include:

- Capture and stabilize Ember-wells.
- Escort or intercept faction resource caravans.
- Protect or destroy siphon devices.
- Capture watchtowers, field camps, and forward respawn positions.
- Fight world bosses while competing with the enemy faction.
- Carry unstable resources to a controlled outpost before banking them.
- Defend quest locations and supply routes during faction events.

Territorial control may temporarily unlock travel, field services, resources, or faction vendors. It must not create a permanent power snowball that prevents the losing faction from recovering.

Capital-Invasion Rules

Individual invaders may scout, sabotage limited military targets, hunt marked military targets, and attempt small resource thefts.

Organized forces may breach gates, disable defensive structures, capture staging points, contest an Ember store, and challenge a faction commander.

Confirmed limits:

- Beginner districts are inaccessible to invaders.
- Military/invasion subzones have no topology or authority path into beginner districts.
- Essential character services cannot be permanently disabled.
- Guards make unsupported attacks dangerous but do not replace defenders.
- Defenders receive a clear alert and a fast route to the threatened capital.
- Invasion results are temporary and recover after a defined cycle.
- A successful invasion cannot permanently transfer ownership of a faction capital.

Assault windows, target order, participant capacity, victory rules, reset time, and reward values remain TBD.

Mandatory-PvP Protection Rules

Protection comes from world structure and enforcement, not optional flagging.

- Rival players cannot enter faction beginner districts through ordinary world travel. Faction capitals inside those territories follow their separate infiltration and invasion rules.
- Safe mixed-city sanctuary policy rejects hostile ability activation and hostile effect application when the authoritative source or target is protected.
- Projectiles, persistent areas, periodic effects, summons, traps, forced movement, and other proxies pass the same server protection check at each gameplay application.
- Mixed-territory PvP cannot be disabled outside an explicit server-authoritative sanctuary or protected subzone.
- Respawn areas prevent immediate re-kills.
- Repeat-victim rewards rapidly decay toward zero.
- Killing a greatly lower-power player provides no normal kill reward.
- Suspicious reciprocal kills and kill trading provide no progression.
- High-risk repeat killers may receive visible bounties.
- Invasions cannot expose tutorial players or required beginner services.

Faction Population Rules

Population imbalance must be managed without hidden damage or health bonuses.

- Measure active faction population by world, region, layer, and time window.
- Prefer contested layers with healthy opposing populations when capacity allows.
- Avoid unnecessary one-faction layers.
- Offer visible, capped resource or progression incentives to an underrepresented faction.
- Give defenders timely invasion travel and alerts.
- Prevent territorial rewards from creating permanent dominance.
- Preserve recovery routes after a sequence of losses.

Exact layer ratios, capacity rules, incentives, and faction-creation controls remain TBD.

Open Decisions

- Which existing settlements become the two faction capitals.
- Whether Glasswake Reach is faction-owned, neutral, or mixed in the final world.
- Final faction borders and travel fiction.

- Safe mixed-city locations beyond Kindlehold.
- Capital invasion routes, objectives, schedules, and recovery.
- Decided, not open: cross-faction grouping is forbidden everywhere, including neutral safe cities (owner decision on Issue #115, 2026-10-11).
- Regional server boundaries and how combat state transfers between them.